

14.3. LightScribe

One of the main problems with CD face labels is getting the alignment exactly right. Even if you do have a label fixing applicator, the alignment may go off, or bubbles might form between the label sticker and the CD face, spoiling your sticker. One solution is to use LightScribe (www.lightscribe.com), a hardware-based device that uses specially coated CD-R, DVD+R and DVD-R discs to laser-etch your CD face artwork without all the above-mentioned hassles.

To use LightScribe you need the following:

- A LightScribe-enabled CD or DVD-Writer
- Specially coated writeable CDs or DVDs
- A LightScribe-compatible label creation software
- The LightScribe system software

LightScribe comes as part of regular CD and DVD-Writers, and are available from many popular vendors both as internal as well as external disc writers. Visit the site and follow the links to find out vendors who can provide you with LightScribe-enabled devices in your area. LightScribe discs are regular writeable CDs and/or DVDs but with a special gold coating on the face that will react to the laser etching process. The artwork, however, will only appear in black and white or greyscale as of this writing. The company says they are planning to bring out colour background discs this year (2006). LightScribe-enabled label creation software will recognise the presence of a LightScribe disc writer and can send your print output directly to the device for laser etching. You can try out SureThing SE (www.lightscribe.com/files/setup.zip), a free label creation software.

In addition to the above, you also need the LightScribe system software. This is normally bundled with your hardware or the label creation software. A universal version is also available along with an extended print contrast utility and label templates in the support area of the LightScribe Web site (www.lightscribe.com/support/index.aspx).